down by the Thames, near Windsor. As well as training, there were things like clay-pigeon shooting organized, which obviously weren't part of the regular routine before an away game. It was all about building us up to the game but making sure we were relaxed as well. I think us young lads were just wandering around with big grins on our faces the whole time. Playing for United in the Cup Final? We were pinching ourselves.

It's amazing how often it's sunny on Cup Final day. In 1996, I remember being surprised how hot it was, even before we got started. I was sweating during the walkabout on the field an hour or so before kick-off. The Liverpool players were strolling around Wembley like it was their own front room: they'd been fitted out in white Armani suits. Some of them were wearing sneakers. Michael Thomas was filming it all on a camcorder. I looked up towards where my mum and dad were going to be sitting. I knew, even then, that the day was going to mean as much to them as it meant to me.

The game was really tough. Tiring, too: the field was very sticky because the grass had been left quite long. Things might have been different if someone had been able to get a goal early on. That might have opened up the game. I had a chance in the first five minutes but David James saved my shot and it went out for a corner. Liverpool tried to stop us playing. We tried to stop them playing. And, well into the second half, it looked like neither team was going to score.

I'd almost missed out on a place in the starting line-up. And I was almost taken off just before the moment that won the game. The boss told me later that he had been about to make a substitution. He'd not been pleased with my corners all afternoon: 'crap corners' he called them. But before the board went up for the change, we won another. I ran over to take it and, as I turned my back on the crowd to put the ball down, I was somehow able to hear this one United supporter's voice above the din:

'Come on, David! Come on!'

I swung it into just the right area, a yard or two outside the six-yard box, towards the penalty spot. David James came out, didn't hold it, and when the ball fell to Eric, a few feet outside the Liverpool area, he volleyed it straight back past James and into the goal. That moment was up there with any I've ever experienced, as intense as the feeling the night the goals went in to win the Treble in Barcelona. A surge of joy and adrenaline just rips through you when you see the ball settle in the back of the net. I think the whole team got to Eric inside a split second and it seemed like he lifted the lot of us off the